

Other manufacturers rushed to compete with Boeing in the jet market. Douglas had hoped to trump the 707 with its jet-powered DC-8, which entered service only 11 months after the Boeing. But the DC-8 ran into production difficulties, and by the time these were ironed out the 707 had an unshakeable lead in the market. The success of the large jets led to a demand for smaller, shorter-range jet airliners that was quantitatively far greater. Through the 1960s Boeing continued to show infallible judgment, scoring with the three-engined 727 and the two-engined 737.

European manufacturers chipped in with aircraft such as the Caravelle and the highly successful British Aircraft Corporation BAC 111. In 1966 Douglas produced the impressive short-haul DC-9, a resounding commercial success, but too late to save the cash-strapped company from a takeover by McDonnell the following year.

Shrinking world

One of the major worries that had made airline executives hesitant about jet airliners was the threat of overcapacity. The new airliners not only had more seats but, because of their faster journey times, could make twice as many flights a day. This offered a tempting economic prospect, as long as the seats could be filled. Yet there was no evidence that people would travel in such quantities. In 1957, before the jets were introduced, for the first time more passengers



SEXUAL EXPLOITATION

In the late 1960s and early 1970s, the blatant use of air hostess sex appeal to sell seats on airliners became universal practice in the industry. Here Southwest Airlines cabin staff adopt a thigh-revealing pose.

crossed the Atlantic by air than by sea. But even if all the sea passengers converted to air travel, there would not be anything like enough of them to fill the fleets of jets rolling off the production lines. In any event, jet travel generated a large-scale movement of people that, without jet airliners, would not have existed at all.

Previously airliners had offered travelers an alternative to ships and trains for journeys they would have made in any case. Now people were tempted into making journeys when previously they would have stayed where they were, or at least not have traveled as far, especially since ticket prices were becoming more affordable. The growth of passenger miles flown on long-distance routes in the first decade of jet travel was astonishing – for TWA, for example, the figure rose from 4.6 billion in 1958 to 19.1 billion in 1969, and for Pan Am from 3.8 billion to 17.1 billion. In effect, jets did not just transform air travel; they changed the world. As Pan Am boss Juan Trippe, one of the first to sign up for the 707, proclaimed: “In one fell swoop we have shrunken the Earth.”

Jet-set era

The growth in passenger numbers inevitably required airports to expand and improve their facilities. Air-traffic control had to be upgraded to cope with the increasingly crowded skies. Fortunately, onboard systems were making notable progress in the 1960s – the first autopilot landing on a scheduled flight was achieved by a Caravelle in 1964. On the whole, jets could fairly claim to increase safety and reliability as well as speed and comfort. Passengers were amazed at how quiet and smooth air travel had become. Advertising the first coast-to-coast jet service in the United States in 1959, American Airlines boasted that “engine noise and vibration, the two factors that contribute most to travel fatigue, have all but vanished.”

The new experience of jet flight became part of the wider phenomenon of the 1960s, with its

ebullient popular culture and its worship of youth, sex, and fun. There was still an air of glamour surrounding long-distance flight, but it was far from the propeller era of well-groomed sophisticates sipping cocktails in an airborne bar. Jet travel was slick, brash, and totally modern. The press invented the term “jet set” for the bright young things who partied one night in New York and the next in Swinging London. The steps down from a 707 provided a natural photo opportunity for starlets, and airports turned into arenas for welcoming pop stars – a phenomenon that reached its peak in the astonishing scenes

FUTURISTIC STYLE

Paris' Charles de Gaulle airport was one of a new generation of facilities built to cope with the rapid expansion of air travel brought about by the introduction of jet airliners. Its futuristic appearance reflected the new importance of airports as architectural style-setters – the cathedrals of the late 20th century, as train stations had been for the 1800s.



NOT A PLAIN PLANE

From 1965 Braniff decided to shake up its reputation as a reliable but dull airline by painting its aircraft in bold colors. The campaign pulled in extra customers by the thousand. This aircraft, Alexander Calder's DC-8 Flying Colors, dates from 1973.